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Is This Normal?

Nobody warned me about this.

The perimenopause reset — the symptoms no one explained, and what actually helps.

You're not crazy. You're not broken. You might be in perimenopause.

If you're somewhere in your 40s (sometimes late 30s), exhausted, not sleeping, anxious for no reason, foggy, gaining weight you can't explain — and you've been told "your labs are fine" — read this.

Perimenopause can start up to **10 years** before your last period, and it touches almost everything: sleep, mood, memory, body. Most women are never told. That ends here.

WHAT THIS IS

A clear map: name what's happening, track it, learn the small levers that help, and walk into your doctor's office prepared — not dismissed.

STEP 1

Is it perimenopause? The symptom check

Tick everything you've noticed in the last few months. There's no "pass" — this is just to see the whole picture in one place.

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Trouble falling / staying asleep | ☐ Fatigue / no energy |
| ☐ Night sweats | ☐ Low libido |
| ☐ Hot flashes | ☐ Vaginal dryness |
| ☐ Anxiety or dread | ☐ Joint aches / stiffness |
| ☐ Irritability / shorter fuse | ☐ Heart palpitations |
| ☐ Low mood / tearfulness | ☐ Headaches / migraines |
| ☐ Brain fog / word-finding | ☐ Dry skin / thinning hair |
| ☐ Forgetfulness | ☐ Itchy or crawling skin |
| ☐ Irregular or changing periods | ☐ Breast tenderness |
| ☐ Heavier or lighter bleeding | ☐ Dizziness |
| ☐ Weight gain (esp. belly) | ☐ Tinnitus / ringing ears |
| ☐ Bloating | ☐ Crying spells |

Three or more, on and off, in your 40s? Perimenopause is very likely on the table. This page is for YOU and your doctor — not a diagnosis.

STEP 2

The symptom tracker

Pick your top 3 symptoms. Rate each 1–5 for a few weeks. Patterns (and triggers) jump out fast — and it's gold for your doctor.

Date	Symptom 1 (1-5)	Symptom 2 (1-5)	Symptom 3 (1-5)	Sleep / notes

STEP 3

The small levers that help

You can't out-discipline hormones — but these daily basics genuinely take the edge off for most women. Pick two to start.

- **Protein + strength.** Aim protein every meal; lift something heavy 2–3×/week. Protects muscle, mood, metabolism.
- **Cool, dark, boring sleep.** Cool room, consistent bedtime, screens down early. Sleep is the master lever.
- **Dial back alcohol + late caffeine.** Both worsen hot flashes, anxiety, and 3 a.m. wake-ups.
- **Daily movement + sunlight.** A walk outside resets mood and circadian rhythm.
- **Magnesium-rich foods / calming wind-down.** Greens, nuts, seeds; a 10-min unwind ritual.
- **Stress is hormonal too.** Five slow breaths, twice a day. Cortisol amplifies everything here.

STEP 4

The doctor visit script

Bring your symptom check + tracker. Ask these out loud so you leave with options, not a brush-off:

- “ Based on my age and symptoms, could this be perimenopause?
- “ What are my options — including hormone therapy (HRT) — and the risks and benefits for me?
- “ If not hormones, what else can help my worst symptoms?
- “ Should we check thyroid, iron, B12, or vitamin D to rule things out?
- “ If you're not sure, can you refer me to a menopause specialist?

IF YOU'RE DISMISSED

"I hear you, but my quality of life is affected and I'd like to explore my options or a referral." You're allowed to advocate for yourself.

This guide is educational, not medical advice. Always make treatment decisions with a qualified healthcare provider.

You're not losing your mind.

Say these. They're true.

- My symptoms are real, even if my labs look "normal."
- I'm allowed to ask for help and a second opinion.
- This is a transition, not the end of me.
- Taking care of myself now is not vanity — it's health.

The one thing I'll do for myself this week:

Now you have the words — and the map.

You were never crazy. You were under-informed. Track it, try a lever or two, and walk into that appointment ready. You deserve to feel like yourself again.

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